# Backlog Item Anatomy

What a good epic, feature and story look like, with one running example from big bet to thin slice.

Break Down Work · Epics, Features & Stories · INVEST (Bill Wake) · Given / When / Then

HOW TO READ IT

✓ Good example, and why it works

✕ Weak example, and what's wrong

RUNNING EXAMPLE — *An online grocery service wants more customers to come back and order again. Follow it down the levels.*

## 1 Epic

THE BIG BET

**A big bet that should deliver a business outcome. Broken into features.**

WEEKS TO MONTHS · OFTEN SEVERAL TEAMS

TEMPLATE

*We believe [doing this] for [these people] will achieve [this outcome]. We'll know we're right when [measure].*

✓ GOOD · Reorder made easy

We believe making it quick to repeat a past order, for returning customers, will increase repeat orders. We'll know when weekly repeat orders rise from 22% to 30% in 3 months.

*Names the people, the outcome and a measure, so it can be proven wrong.*

✗ WEAK · Reorder platform

"Build the new reorder platform."

*A solution, not an outcome. No measure, so nobody can tell if it worked, or when to stop.*

## 2 Feature

A USABLE CAPABILITY

**Something users can see and use that delivers part of the epic's value.**

A FEW ITERATIONS · ONE OR TWO TEAMS

TEMPLATE

*[Capability] so that [benefit].*

✓ GOOD · One-tap reorder

One-tap reorder of a past basket, so returning customers can repeat a weekly shop in under a minute.

*Usable on its own, with a clear benefit to a named user.*

✗ WEAK · Reorder back end

"Reorder API and database changes."

*A technical layer. Nobody can use it alone, so it delivers no value until everything else is done.*

## 3 Story

A THIN VERTICAL SLICE

**A thin, vertical slice of a feature that a user can use. Finishes in days.**

DAYS · WITHIN YOUR SLE · ONE TEAM

TEMPLATE

*As a [type of user], I want [goal] so that [reason].*

+ acceptance criteria: Given · When · Then

INVEST — Independent · Negotiable · Valuable · Estimable · Small · Testable

✓ GOOD · SEE MY LAST ORDER

As a returning customer, I want to see my last order on the home page so that I can reorder it quickly.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

Given I've ordered before, when I open the app,
then I see my last order with a Reorder button.
Given an item is out of stock, when I reorder,
then I'm offered a substitute.

*Valuable to a user, small, and testable from the criteria.*

✗ WEAK · TECHNICAL TASK

"As a developer, I want a reorder table so that the data is stored."

*No user value. It's a task inside a real story.*

✗ WEAK · TOO BIG

"As a customer, I want to reorder, edit my basket and schedule delivery."

*Three stories joined by "and". Split it (see Story Splitting).*

### TASK

A step the team takes to finish a story.
Not tracked as value.

### SPIKE

Time-boxed research to answer a question.
Its output is knowledge.

### BUG

Doesn't work as agreed.
Fix fast, or order it like any other item.

### ENABLER

Technical work that makes future value possible, such as paying down debt.

*"Who is this for, and what will be better for them?"*

*"Could a user use this slice on its own?"*

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